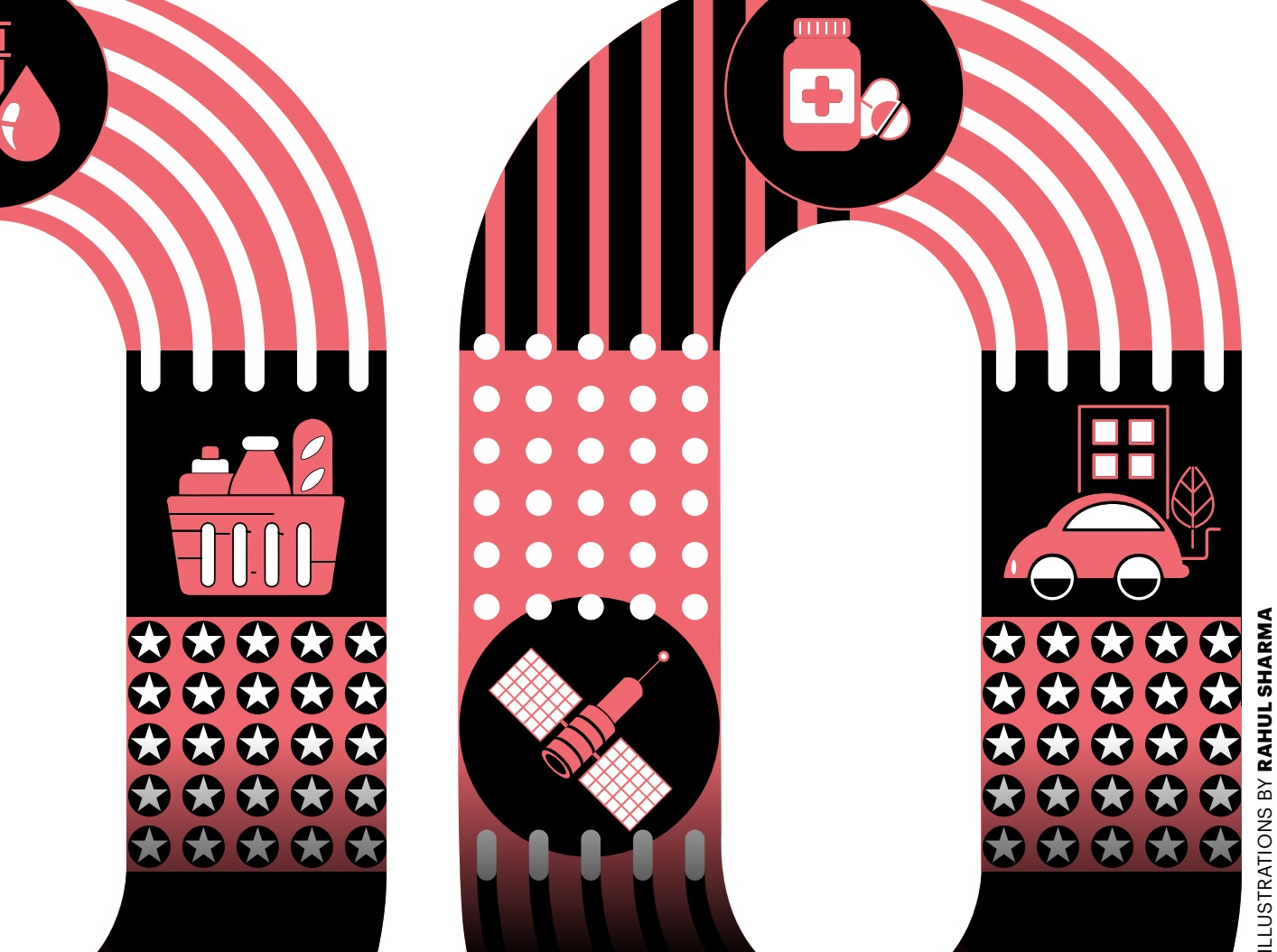




ILLUSTRATIONS BY RAHUL SHARMA

IF SOMEONE HAD told you that the list of top ten profitable companies would one day have five entries from the public sector, you might have laughed it off, right? Well, you can't be blamed as, for years, PSUs were branded as a den of inefficiency and political interference. Not anymore.

In FY20, the BT500 profit-wise listing had three public sector undertakings (PSUs), State Bank of India (SBI), Coal India and Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC), in the top 10. In FY18, only ONGC and NTPC had made the cut. But the FY25 list has—apart from SBI, Coal India and ONGC—Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) and Power Finance Corporation (PFC) as well. Of course, the big boys in the private sector—ranging from diversified conglomerates such as Reliance Industries or RIL (first position) to those in banking and financial services such as HDFC Bank (3rd rank)—also delivered a solid performance as India Inc's profit vanguards.

As corporate India enters challenging times, thanks to geopolitical uncertainties and the US' tariff onslaught, it will be tested like never before. As the country faces these challenges with grit and will, can its most profitable companies, especially the PSUs, act as engines of a national revival?

PAT RANK

2025	Company
1	Reliance Industries
2	State Bank Of India
3	HDFC Bank
4	ICICI Bank
5	Tata Consultancy Services
6	Life Insurance Corporation of India
7	Oil & Natural Gas Corporation
8	Bharti Airtel
9	Coal India
10	Power Finance Corporation